



SUJET STATAPP 321 - 2026-2027



Sujet proposé par : Präg Patrick - patrick.prag@ensae.fr
Organisme : CREST
Catégorie : Sociologie Quantitative
Sujet :
Conspiracy Theory Beliefs in Europe: Analysis of the European Social Survey

Description du sujet :

Believing in conspiracy theories is becoming an important social problem?social movements like QAnon in the US or anti-vaxxers are having important real-life consequences, swaying elections and endangering public health. But who believes in conspiracy theories, and does this vary across societies?

The European Social Survey 2020?22 has collected data in 32 European countries, including information about whether participants believe in conspiracy theories such as that a secret small elite is making all major decisions in politics. Using random-effects multilevel models, we will describe and model the variation in conspiracy theory beliefs across countries to better understand what drives beliefs in them: Political traditions and partisanship? Religion? Education? And how are beliefs in conspiracy theories related to Covid-19 vaccination behavior?

While random-effects models are often neglected in econometrics courses (because, no one can deny it, fixed-effects models have important features and are easier to understand), in certain situations such as country comparisons, random effects models (also known as multi-level models) come in quite handy. For instance, random effects models allow analyzing the overall country effect or allow analyzing cross-level interactions.

Statistical software will be Stata or R, depending on the students' preferences.

At the end of this project, students will have:

- An excellent understanding of multilevel models; a flexible technique that is extremely useful for analyzing clustered data, such as survey respondents clustered in countries, citizens clustered in neighborhoods, or students clustered in classrooms
- An excellent understanding of the European Social Survey, the most important European sample survey of attitudes, values, and behaviors. The ESS is an incredibly useful and versatile source of data, and having an understanding of ESS data is an important asset for answering all sorts of research questions about Europeans' attitudes, values, and behaviors, as well as social change.

Données du sujet :

The European Social Survey (ESS) is a repeated, cross-sectional survey that since 2002 collects data on the attitudes, values, and behaviors of Europeans. Data are collected every two years and are publicly available. In every wave, 20?35 European countries participate, each contributing a nationally representative sample of 1,000?3,000 respondents. ESS data have been analyzed in thousands of academic publications so far and are an invaluable source of information about European societies. Data and exhaustive information can be found on the ESS website: <https://www.europeansocialsurvey.org/>

Modèles envisagés du sujet :

Random-effects (multilevel) models to describe and model cross-country variation in conspiracy theory beliefs, including overall country effects and cross-level interactions. Statistical software: Stata or R, depending on student preference.

Bibliographie du sujet :

Douglas, Karen M., Joseph E. Uscinski, Robbie M. Sutton, Aleksandra Cichocka, Turkey Nefes, Chee Siang Ang, and Farzin Deravi. 2019. "Understanding Conspiracy Theories." *Political Psychology* 40(S1):3-35. doi: <https://doi.org/10.1111/pops.12568>. This gives some background for social science research into conspiracy theories.

Robson, Karen, and David Pevalin. 2016. *Multilevel Modeling in Plain Language*. Sage. This is an excellent book that explains random-effects/multilevel modeling without detail, with Stata code available in the book and R code available on the website.

Gelman, Andrew, and Jennifer Hill. 2007. *Data Analysis Using Regression and Multilevel/Hierarchical Models*. Cambridge University Press. doi: <https://doi.org/10.1017/CBO9780511790942>. This is an excellent book that explains random-effects/multilevel modeling in great detail, with R code available.

Hanson, Tim, Marc Helbling, Rahsaan Maxwell, Richard Traunmüller, Kostas Gemenis, and Levente Littvay. 2021. "Developing a COVID-19 Module for the European Social Survey." *Measurement Instruments for the Social Sciences* 3(9):1-6. doi: <https://doi.org/10.1186/s42409-021-00029-4>

Wooldridge, Jeffrey M. 2010. *Econometric Analysis of Cross Section and Panel Data*, 2nd ed. MIT Press.

Wooldridge, Jeffrey M. 2016. *Introductory Econometrics. A Modern Approach*, 6th ed. Cengage.

Notation du sujet :**Commentaires :**